

responsibilities seriously. We supply locally manufactured products in India and our practices are compliant with relevant laws and regulations. Dahua maintains high standards to ensure product and data security. We do not store or manage customer data, and we do not transmit data to any third parties. We adhere to common standards for security practices in our industry and comply with all applicable laws, regulations and business ethics of each market in which we operate."

DANGEROUS LIAISONS

An MoD source says that Hikvision began as a Chinese state entity and maintains close ties with the country's Communist regime. The China Electronics Technology Group Corporation (CETC), a fully state-owned defence-industrial conglomerate, is its largest shareholder. "With generous state support at home and low-cost sales abroad, Hikvision has become the world's surveillance heavyweight. Its facilities can churn out 260,000 cameras daily. In 2019, it produced nearly a quarter of the world's surveillance cameras, with sales in more than 150 countries," he claims.

In fact, such is the pricing of Chinese CCTVs on account of economies of scale that the incentives of importing the technology and marketing, rebranding and selling the same as 'Made in India' far outweigh the benefits of investment in local manufacturing or research and development. As a result, most leading Indian and global brands have discontinued their own product lines. For example, for CCTVs, the Bhopal Smart City project opted for products of a prominent US-based firm. However, it got all cameras manufactured by the Chinese behemoth Dahua. The same model has been replicated by many companies for installation at sensitive government establishments.

The threat perception involving Chinese-made electronic/ digital devices is not a new development. In 2014, based on inputs from the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (Cert-In), the Indian Air Force asked its personnel and their families not to use Xiaomi Redmi 1 smartphones. The phones were suspected to have been forwarding the phone number, device identifier, address book numbers and text messages back to servers in China.

Similarly, in November 2017, three months after the border standoff in Doklam, the army asked all troops on the China border to format their smartphones and delete Chinese-origin apps like Truecaller and WeChat. The applications, 42 in all, were suspected to contain spyware or malicious ware linked to Chinese hackers. In 2015, top US-based cybersecurity firm FireEye had claimed in a report that Chinese hackers were spying on Indian government and commercial entities for political, economic and military information. Also in 2015, the defence ministry had restricted internet access for its personnel in New Delhi's South Block and asked them not to use wi-fi and Bluetooth-enabled devices due to fears of hacking. Over the last two years, the Union government has banned 100 plus Chinese mobile phone apps citing a "threat to national security".

Intelligence sleuths recently came across a case wherein an American company claimed to be supplying 'made in USA' products over the past two-three years, but which was discovered in August 2022 to have Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) certification showing that they had been manufactured at the Hikvision factory in Shanghai. The cameras are being supplied to critical departments such as the National Highways Authority of India, the J&K Police, the Airports Authority of India and the Union ministry of